

MARSILI

*An Interactive Hybrid Game Experience for Heritage, Science, and
Discovery*

Project Brief

Bologna, Italy
Museum and Heritage Interactive Media Design

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Table of Contents

1. Project Overview
2. Context and Background
3. The Design Problem
4. Main Concept
5. Why Marsili Works as a Subject
6. Target Audience
7. Learning Goals
8. What the Game Actually Solves
9. Hybrid Design Direction
10. Digital Elements
11. Physical Elements and Spatial Logic
12. Accessibility and Inclusion
13. Narrative Tone & Experience Feel
14. Content Strategy
15. Gameplay Structure and Interaction Flow
16. Prototype Direction
17. Project Values and Success Criteria
18. Interaction Design Principles
19. User Journey and Narrative Progression
20. Content Inventory and Star Assets
21. Accessibility, Language, and Usability Requirements
22. Team Roles and Alliance
23. Constraints and Risks

24. Evaluation Criteria

25. Theoretical Grounding

26. Summary

1. Project Overview

Echoes of Marsili is an interactive hybrid game focused on the life, scientific work, and legacy of Luigi Ferdinando Marsili, a prominent figure in Bologna's history. Designed for museum and heritage environments, the project shifts visitors from passive observers to active participants. Its main objectives are to promote movement, object interaction, narrative engagement, and discovery, deepening engagement with Marsili's heritage and enriching the museum experience.

The experience uses Marsili's original collections and manuscripts, presenting him as a guide. Visitors explore the museum from his perspective, engaging with both physical artifacts and digital interactions for a unified, accessible experience.

Human-centered interactive design principles guide all aspects of the experience, including navigation, information delivery, object interaction, and feedback. The aim is to make museum visits feel like genuine exploration rather than a requirement.

2. Context and Background

2.1 The Marsili Collection in Bologna

Luigi Ferdinando Marsili's manuscripts, scientific instruments, maps, and natural history specimens are preserved in Bologna's museums. This authentic foundation ensures the project is rooted in Marsili's actual work and focuses on enabling meaningful visitor interaction.

Marsili's diverse roles as scientist, military officer, traveller, cartographer, institution-builder, and collector provide rich material for narratives on exploration, scientific observation, and the challenges of understanding the world in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries.

2.2 The Museum as a Starting Point

The course established a key methodological principle: heritage design should begin with context rather than technology. This principle guided the project from the outset. The museum environment, its objects, spatial layout, and visitor movement patterns serve as core design materials. Digital elements are added to enhance and extend the experience, not to replace or overshadow it.

There is also a practical reason to prioritize the museum setting over digital screens. Visitors who choose to attend in person should be rewarded with meaningful activities that make their physical presence valuable.

3. The Design Problem

3.1 Passive Museum Engagement

In most traditional museums, visitors walk through rooms, read labels, observe objects, and move on, with limited opportunities for participation or interpretation. This reflects the historical structure of museum experiences rather than a criticism of the institutions. As a result, visitors may leave without genuine engagement, and the information often fails to resonate.

Echoes of Marsili addresses this challenge by replacing passive observation with active participation. Visitors engage directly within the space, moving beyond traditional museum passivity.

3.2 Accessibility and Inclusivity

A second major challenge is the risk of exclusion. When museum content relies on a single language, prior academic knowledge, or extensive text, accessibility is limited. Families with young children, non-Italian speakers, or those unfamiliar with seventeenth-century science may feel excluded, even unintentionally.

Accessibility is a core design principle. The experience must be effective for visitors unfamiliar with Marsili, those less confident with digital systems, and individuals with diverse expectations. This requirement shapes all aspects, from interface language to navigation structure.

3.3 Making Heritage Feel Alive

A key design challenge is making Marsili's world feel vibrant rather than static. Manuscripts, instruments, and maps, though fascinating, can seem distant and lack immediate meaning for those unfamiliar with their context.

The project aims to transform these objects into active narrative elements that visitors engage with rather than simply observe. Shifting from static objects to narrative anchors is the core design challenge.

4. Main Concept

The core concept is that visitors do not simply learn about Marsili; they follow him. Marsili is presented as a narrative presence, inviting visitors to adopt his habits of observation and inquiry. Visitors discover his world by uncovering what he left behind, rather than just viewing displays.

This approach changes the visitor's relationship to the content. Instead of passively receiving information, visitors engage with Marsili's way of thinking. Questions about how he observed, what he collected, and how he organized knowledge are built into the interaction design, making the visit feel like exploration rather than instruction.

The experience is structured as a progressive journey of discovery. Visitors scan, touch, explore, and unlock narrative layers throughout the space. Each interaction reveals new insights, such as a manuscript that illuminates a scientific question, an instrument linked to an expedition, or a map that contextualizes Marsili's work. These discoveries collectively build an understanding of Marsili's significance and enduring legacy. Themes such as observation, measurement, travel, evidence, and the relationship between field exploration and institutional knowledge are not just subject headings; they are the emotional and intellectual threads that connect the experience.

5. Why Marsili Works as a Subject

Some historical figures are challenging subjects for interactive experiences due to abstract significance or limited material. Marsili, however, offers rich, tangible resources for exploration.

Marsili's career encompassed oceanographic research, military engineering, mapping, natural history collecting, and the founding of scientific institutions. This diversity enables visitors to experience multiple facets of his life, enriching the overall experience.

Marsili's work is marked by genuine adventure. He traveled extensively, was captured and sold into slavery before being freed, studied the ocean floor, and created some of the earliest detailed maps of the Bosphorus. His biography provides compelling narrative material without embellishment.

Crucially, Marsili's legacy is physically present in Bologna's museum collections. Manuscripts, instruments, and specimens are authentic objects that visitors can encounter directly, providing tangible reference points for the interactive design.

6. Target Audience

The primary audience is visitors aged 14-27 interested in the humanities, science, history, interactive storytelling, and digital media. Many are familiar with platforms like Twine and prefer experiences involving exploration, choice, and active participation. The project is designed for those who find traditional museum exhibitions too static or text-heavy, offering a more engaging and immersive alternative. By integrating hybrid storytelling, object-based exploration, and interactive digital elements, the project aims to make museum visits more dynamic and meaningful.

Accessibility and inclusive interaction are central to the project. The experience accommodates visitors with diverse sensory and accessibility needs, including those who are visually or hearing impaired. Features such as subtitles, audio guidance, readable text, clear visual hierarchy, and intuitive navigation ensure that sensory limitations do not hinder participation. By combining visual, textual, and audio communication, the project enables a wide range of visitors to explore Marsili's world independently.

7. Learning Goals

7.1 Understanding Marsili and His Heritage

The primary learning goal is for visitors to understand who Marsili was, beyond just his name and dates. The experience presents Marsili as a thinking, working individual whose curiosity led him to measure ocean depths, collect specimens across Europe and the Ottoman Empire, and found enduring institutions.

By the end of the experience, visitors should have a clear sense of Marsili's contribution to scientific culture in Bologna and understand what it meant to pursue knowledge as he did.

7.2 Understanding Scientific Inquiry and Knowledge Production

A second, equally important learning goal is to show how scientific knowledge is created. Marsili's work demonstrates that discovery occurs not only in laboratories but also in the field, on ships, through correspondence between scholars, and in the careful accumulation of specimens and measurements.

Through interaction design, visitors engage directly with the observational, evidence-based thinking that underpins Marsili's work. The goal is not for them to memorize facts, but to develop an intuitive sense of the relationship between curiosity, observation, and knowledge creation.

7.3 Heritage, Interpretation, and Curiosity

The third learning goal concerns heritage itself. The experience helps visitors see museum objects and manuscripts not as inert historical artifacts, but as meaningful traces of intellectual work. A manuscript is not just an old document; it is evidence of how someone thought, what questions they asked, and how they recorded their findings.

If visitors leave the experience with a slightly different relationship to museum collections — more curious, more willing to ask what an object means rather than just what it is — the project will have achieved something real.

8. What the Game Actually Solves

8.1 Transforming Passive Observation into Active Participation

The most direct problem the project addresses is passivity. The experience replaces the conventional museum dynamic of walking past, reading labels, and moving on with one where visitors are continually participating: with screen, sound, and interpret findings as a player. It changes the visitor's relationship to the material, their level of attention, and what they're likely to remember after they leave.

8.2 Improving Accessibility and Engagement

By designing for a broad audience from the outset, the project addresses accessibility challenges. Clear visual hierarchy, readable text, touch-based interaction, and multilingual support ensure the experience does not inadvertently exclude its intended visitors.

8.3 Creating Meaningful Digital Interaction

Finally, the project addresses a common issue in digital museum experiences: digital elements can create confusion rather than clarity. If a system is too complex, poorly integrated with the physical space, or disconnected from heritage content, it hinders rather than enhances usability and interaction clarity as non-negotiable design requirements. The technology has to serve the heritage experience, not compete with it.

9. Hybrid Design Direction

Hybrid, in this context, means the experience exists in the relationship between digital and physical space. Physical objects in the museum serve as entry points to digital narrative layers, while digital interactions guide visitors to specific locations. Both dimensions are designed to be interdependent.

This approach addresses a core weakness of purely digital museum experiences: they can be accessed anywhere, making the physical visit less relevant. A hybrid system gives visitors a reason to be present, making the museum itself part of the interaction.

The hybrid system integrates touch-based interaction, QR-supported exploration, object-linked storytelling, and digital narrative layers within the museum. These elements work together seamlessly, allowing visitors to engage without needing to understand the underlying system.

10. Digital Elements

10.1 Twine-Based Narrative Structure

Twine is central to the project's digital architecture, supporting branching narratives, interactive decision-making, and progressive information discovery without requiring a custom-built game environment. It manages complex storytelling while remaining practical for the project's development scope. It functions as the bridge between the physical and digital dimensions of the experience. A visitor scans a code attached to an object, a manuscript display, or a location in the museum, and is taken to a specific narrative layer or interactive element. This approach keeps the interaction physically grounded while making it easy to update and expand digital content without changing the physical installation.

10.2 Cross-Device Compatibility

The experience works across phones, tablets, and computer displays, allowing flexible deployment based on the museum's infrastructure and visitors' devices. Animations and feedback systems support atmosphere and guidance, but the core experience does not depend on them for essential communication.

11. Physical Elements and Spatial Logic

The project's physical dimension is rooted in the actual Marsili museum environment. Manuscripts, scientific instruments, maps, display cases, and the museum's spatial organization are integral to the interaction design. They are not backdrops to the digital experience; they are its primary material.

Spatial design emphasizes clarity and natural movement. Visual cues, interactive touchpoints, and object references guide visitors without the need for instructions. The experience unfolds through movement, making the physical journey itself part of the story.

This approach reflects the project's commitment to human-centred design. The system is intuitive because it aligns with the way visitors naturally move through a museum.

12. Accessibility and Inclusion

12.1 Inclusive and Intuitive Interaction

Accessibility is treated as a design foundation, not an afterthought. Every interaction in the experience is designed to be understandable without explanation. If a visitor needs to read a set of instructions before they can engage with the system, the design has already failed.

This means the interaction patterns have to be consistent, predictable, and visually clear. Navigation elements should be immediately recognisable. Feedback should be immediate and unambiguous. The cognitive load on the visitor should be kept to a minimum so that their attention can go toward the heritage content rather than toward figuring out how the system works.

12.2 Multilingual and Multi-Modal Communication

The project is designed with multilingual accessibility in mind. Bologna's museum visitors include international tourists, exchange students, and visitors from across Italy who may not read academic Italian comfortably. Key content is communicated through both visual and textual elements, supporting visitors with hearing impairments and ensuring the experience is effective in environments where audio is not suitable. Experience is designed to foster confidence. Visitors should always know what to do and where to go. When uncertainty arises, the system provides natural guidance. The challenge should come from the heritage content, not the interface.

12.3 A Comfortable and Guided Experience

The experience is structured to create a sense of confidence rather than anxiety. Visitors should feel that they know what they're doing and where they're going at every point. When they're uncertain, the system should offer guidance naturally rather than leaving them stranded. This isn't about making the experience too easy — it's about making sure the challenge comes from the heritage content itself, not from the interface.

13. Narrative Tone and Experience Feel

13.1 Curiosity, Discovery, and Immersion

The narrative tone is grounded in curiosity. Marsili was driven to understand everything he encountered, and this quality shapes the experience. Each interaction is designed to leave visitors eager to discover what comes next, rather than feeling they have completed a section.

Immersion is used carefully here. The project isn't trying to simulate Marsili's world in a way that asks visitors to forget they're in a museum. The immersion is more subtle than that: it comes from the consistency of the narrative framing, the quality of the content, and the feeling that the visit is building toward something coherent.

13.2 Respectful and Engaging Heritage Storytelling

The project approaches Marsili's legacy with respect, while avoiding a dry or overly formal presentation. It seeks to convey both the significance of his work and the human qualities that enabled it.

13.3 Creating Emotional Connection

Perhaps the most important dimension of the narrative tone is the attempt to create an emotional connection between visitors and the material. History stays with people when a key narrative goal is to create an emotional connection between visitors and the material. History is most memorable when it feels personal. The project highlights moments where Marsili's curiosity, challenges, ambition, or joy in discovery become relatable to visitors. Collected specimens and archival materials from the museum collections serve as the primary narrative anchors. These materials aren't used merely as illustrations of the story—they are the story. Each object or document reveals something specific about how Marsili worked and what he was trying to understand.

14. Content Strategy

14.1 Heritage-Driven Narrative Content

The content strategy centers entirely on Marsili's actual legacy. Manuscripts, maps, scientific instruments, collected specimens, and archival materials from the museum collections serve as the primary narrative anchors. These materials aren't used merely as illustrations of the story—they are the story. Each object or document reveals something specific about how Marsili worked and what he was trying to understand.

14.2 Interactive and Meaningful Content Integration

Every piece of content within the experience is connected to an interaction and to narrative progression. There's no content that exists simply to be read without doing anything. Objects unlock stories. Documents reveal context. Maps connect to geographical explorations. The content is always embedded in the interaction structure rather than placed alongside it.

14.3 Layered Information Structure

The experience uses a layered content structure. Core information is presented clearly and accessibly for all visitors, while deeper historical and scientific detail is available for those who want it. This approach means the experience doesn't have to choose between accessibility and substance. Both exist within the same system, at different levels of engagement.

15. Gameplay Structure and Interaction Flow

The gameplay structure is built around exploration, interaction, and progressive discovery. Visitors take an active role in uncovering Marsili's world through object-based interaction, narrative prompts, and digital exploration. The interaction flow encourages observation, investigation, interpretation, and the gradual unlocking of different layers of information.

The experience is deliberately not competitive. There are no points, no rankings, no failure states. The emphasis is entirely on curiosity, participation, and meaningful engagement. Visitors are invited to explore at their own pace, following threads that interest them, without feeling tested or evaluated.

Small interactive tasks and narrative progression points guide visitors naturally through different aspects of Marsili's life and contributions. Each interaction reveals new information or deepens the visitor's connection to a specific object, manuscript, or scientific idea.

The gameplay direction remains intentionally flexible to support iterative development and team collaboration during the prototyping phase. But the core interaction logic is clear: visitors engage with heritage materials, receive narrative and educational feedback, and build a progressive understanding of Marsili's legacy through active exploration.

16. Prototype Direction

16.1 Iterative Prototyping Process

The project is developed through an iterative prototyping process. Rather than trying to build a finished experience from the start, the prototype phase is designed to test interaction flow, narrative structure, usability, and overall visitor experience before any final decisions are made about implementation.

16.2 Tools and Formats

The current prototype direction includes Twine-based narrative prototyping, interface and interaction mockups developed through Figma, and low-fidelity paper prototyping for gameplay and spatial interaction testing. Twine is particularly well-suited to demonstrating branching narratives and progression logic. Figma supports visualizing interface structure, navigation flow, and user interaction. Paper prototyping allows the team to test spatial and physical dimensions without committing to a digital build.

16.3 Purpose of Prototyping

The prototype is not a finished product. Its purpose is to validate core interaction and narrative concepts, identify usability challenges early, and give the team something concrete to test with users. Feedback from prototype testing will shape the next iteration of the design, which is exactly how the process should work.

17. Project Values and Success Criteria

The project is guided by four core values: accessibility, curiosity, participation, and meaningful engagement with cultural heritage. These values inform specific design decisions throughout development.

Success is measured by the visitor experience, not by technical completion or visual polish. A successful project is measured by visitor experience rather than technical completion or visual polish. The project should be intuitive and engaging for users of all ages and backgrounds. Visitors should leave with a deeper understanding of Marsili's legacy and feel they actively participated in discovery. If the digital and physical elements feel disconnected, or if the narrative doesn't hold together, the project hasn't succeeded even if individual components work well in isolation.

18. Interaction Design Principles

The interaction design is guided by three core principles: clarity, simplicity, and intuitive navigation. These apply at every level of the system, from the overall navigation structure to individual interface elements.

Every interaction within the experience is built around a clear action-and-response structure. When a visitor scans, touches, selects, or explores an element, the system responds immediately and clearly. There's no ambiguity about whether something worked, what it revealed, or what comes next.

The project follows a user-centered interaction philosophy in which the experience unfolds as a guided journey rather than a sequence of disconnected screens. Careful attention is paid to how visitors enter the experience, how they move between stages, how they receive information, and how they feel when they complete their exploration. Interaction is treated as a meaningful part of the storytelling process, not as a technical necessity.

19. User Journey and Narrative Flow

19.1 Opening and Orientation

The user journey begins with a clear, inviting introduction that establishes the experience as an interactive exploration of Marsili's world, without overwhelming visitors with context. The opening is designed to create curiosity and orientation simultaneously, giving visitors enough information to feel grounded while leaving enough open to pull them forward.

19.2 Progressive Discovery

As visitors move through the experience, they encounter a sequence of interconnected discoveries that gradually reveal different aspects of Marsili's life and work. Narrative progression is supported through interaction with objects, manuscripts, digital storytelling layers, and exploratory tasks. The experience is intentionally flexible — visitors can move at different paces and follow different threads without losing the overall sense of a coherent journey.

19.3 Closure and Reflection

The final stage of the journey is designed to create reflection and meaningful closure. Rather than ending abruptly, the experience reconnects the visitor's exploration to Marsili's broader contribution to science, heritage, and the culture of knowledge. By the end, visitors should feel that they actively participated in a process of discovery and developed a real connection with the historical world they've been exploring.

20. Content Inventory and Star Assets

20.1 Historical and Museum Assets

The project is built around historically significant materials connected to Luigi Ferdinando Marsili and the scientific heritage of Bologna. Core content assets include manuscripts, scientific instruments, cartographic drawings and maps, collected natural history specimens,

archival materials, and museum display environments associated with Marsili's research and institutional contributions.

20.2 Narrative and Interactive Assets

Beyond the physical heritage materials, the project treats narrative and interaction as primary assets in their own right. Marsili's narrative presence functions as a guiding element throughout the experience. Interactive maps, scientific observation mechanics, and object-linked storytelling strengthen the project's identity by transforming historical materials into active components of the visitor journey.

20.3 Experiential Value and Project Identity

These elements are considered star assets because they define the project's uniqueness, atmosphere, and educational value. Their integration into the interaction and narrative structure transforms heritage from a passive exhibition into a participatory experience of scientific research and cultural discovery.

21. Accessibility, Language, and Usability Requirements

21.1 Accessibility as a Core Requirement

Accessibility is not an additional feature to be considered later in the design process. It is a fundamental requirement, present from the first design decision and maintained through every subsequent one. The experience must be understandable and approachable for users of different ages, backgrounds, levels of digital familiarity, and prior knowledge.

21.2 Language and Communication Design

Language used throughout the experience should remain readable, concise, and understandable to a broad audience, avoiding unnecessarily technical terminology. Multilingual support is an important requirement, as the museum audience includes international visitors from diverse cultural and linguistic backgrounds. Even at the prototype stage, the design should remain adaptable for future translation and multilingual expansion.

21.3 Usability and Multi-Modal Interaction

Usability is supported through clean layouts, clear visual hierarchy, legible text, and understandable feedback systems. Sound is treated as an optional enhancement rather than a

required interaction channel. Text, visuals, touch interaction, and spatial guidance should each convey the core experience independently. This reinforces the project's commitment to inclusive and human-centered interaction design.

22. Team Roles and Collaboration

22.1 Collaborative Design Approach

The experience is developed through a collaborative, interdisciplinary design process that integrates heritage research, storytelling, interaction design, visual communication, and digital prototyping. Teamwork is essential to ensure project coherence and quality.

22.2 Distribution of Roles and Responsibilities

Team members contribute to different aspects of the project according to their strengths and areas of focus. Responsibilities may include historical and content research, narrative development, visual and interface design, interaction flow, prototype creation, and technical implementation. This distribution helps maintain a balanced workflow while ensuring that both the educational and interactive aspects of the experience develop in parallel.

22.3 Coordination and Shared Development

The project is a collective design effort in which communication and coordination between team members are essential. Specific responsibilities may continue evolving during development, but the collaboration process ensures that content, interaction, narrative, and visual identity remain connected within a unified experience. This shared workflow supports consistency while encouraging creative problem-solving and iterative design development.

23. Constraints and Risks

23.1 Technical and Development Constraints

One of the primary constraints is the technical complexity of integrating digital interaction with a physical museum environment. The development process must remain manageable within the available time, resources, and the course's technical scope. This requires careful prioritization of features and interaction systems to ensure the final experience remains coherent and achievable within the project timeline.

23.2 Usability and Accessibility Risks

Since the project is designed for a broad audience with different levels of digital familiarity, there's a real risk that overly complex interactions or unclear navigation could create confusion rather than engagement. The interaction design addresses this by focusing on simplicity, intuitive guidance, readable interfaces, and accessible progression. Maintaining a balance between immersion and usability is essential.

23.3 Content Scope and Narrative Balance

Marsili's life and scientific legacy contain extensive historical, scientific, and cultural material. Trying to include too many risks dilutes the experience and overwhelms visitors. The project focuses on selected aspects of Marsili's world that best support interaction, storytelling, and visitor engagement, maintaining narrative coherence while preserving educational depth.

23.4 Meaningful Use of Digital Interaction

Digital elements must not become decorative. Every QR interaction, animation, narrative system, and digital interface is designed to serve a clear purpose within the visitor journey. If a digital element doesn't actively contribute to storytelling, interpretation, guidance, or participation, it shouldn't be included. Technology should strengthen the heritage experience, not distract from it.

24. Evaluation Criteria

24.1 User Experience and Interaction

The project is evaluated based on the clarity of interaction, accessibility, and overall visitor engagement. Key criteria include how effectively the experience communicates Marsili's legacy, how intuitive the user journey feels, and how successfully the physical and digital elements work together within the museum environment.

24.2 Engagement and Educational Value

Another key criterion is the project's ability to create curiosity and meaningful engagement with heritage content. The experience should encourage exploration, support learning through interaction, and clearly demonstrate the integration of storytelling, heritage materials, and interactive design within the prototype experience.

25. Theoretical Grounding

25.1 Design Rooted in Context and Heritage

The project is firmly grounded in the course principle that interactive design should emerge from a real context rather than from technology alone. The Marsili museum environment, its scientific collections, manuscripts, and historical spaces, provide the foundation for the entire experience. Rather than creating a generic digital application, the project develops a heritage-based interaction system that responds directly to the museum context and to the way visitors experience cultural spaces today.

25.2 From Problem Identification to Design Requirements

The project follows the methodological structure introduced in the course, beginning with identifying problems, needs, and requirements. The primary problem identified is the passive nature of many museum experiences. In response, the project proposes an accessible and interactive system that encourages exploration, participation, and discovery. Design requirements such as intuitive navigation, multilingual accessibility, hybrid interaction, and clear user guidance emerge directly from these identified user needs.

25.3 Interaction Design, Prototyping, and Interdisciplinary Practice

Another key theoretical foundation is the course's focus on interaction design as a process shaped by behaviour, usability, and user experience rather than solely by visual appearance. Prototyping tools such as Twine and Figma support the testing of narrative flow, interaction logic, and visitor engagement before final implementation. This reflects the course's emphasis on iterative design, experimentation, and interdisciplinary collaboration within interactive media projects.

25.4 Hybrid Museum Experience and Active Participation

The project further reflects the course's interest in hybrid museum experiences that transform visitors from passive observers into active participants. Marsili's life and scientific legacy are not presented as static historical information but as an interactive process of exploration and discovery. This demonstrates how interactive media design can reinterpret historical and scientific heritage through participation, immersion, and meaningful engagement.

26. Summary

Echoes of Marsili proposes a hybrid interactive heritage experience based on the life, scientific achievements, and cultural legacy of Luigi Ferdinando Marsili in Bologna. Designed for a museum context, the project transforms historical content into an accessible, immersive

journey that encourages visitors to actively explore manuscripts, scientific objects, and narrative elements related to Marsili's world.

The project addresses the challenge of making museum experiences more interactive, intuitive, and accessible to a broad audience. By combining physical heritage elements with digital interaction and narrative exploration, the experience supports learning through discovery and participation. The design emphasizes accessibility, clear interaction, multilingual potential, and flexible engagement for users with different levels of knowledge and digital familiarity.

At the prototype stage, the project is demonstrated through Twine, Figma, and interactive mockups that visualize the narrative flow and user journey. The final experience integrates QR-based interaction, touch-based navigation, animations, and cross-device compatibility depending on the final technical direction. The project presents a contemporary approach to heritage communication by combining interaction design, storytelling, and museum experience into a coherent hybrid system.